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The Furious Fists of Julia

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THE FURIOUS FISTS OF JULIA

(*Author's note: This was written for performers who were interested in exploring unique fight choreography within a DUO. The fights can be as simple or complex as the performers feel best suits their ability.)*

(*Author's note: This was written as a semi-parody of the revenge action movie genre. While there may be vague references to specific movies, knowledge of the movies should not be necessary for the performance or enjoyment of the piece.*)

CHARACTERS (With suggested doubling breakdown)

Julia - Performer 1
Narrator - Performer 2
Riley - Performer 2
Taylor - Performer 2
Boss - Performer 2
Handler - Performer 2
Bad Guy 1 - Performer 1
Bad Guy 2 - Performer 2
Old Lady - Performer 2

(*Start with JULIA facing the audience, sitting at a desk, typing away. NARRATOR stands with back to JULIA facing the back wall - upstage*)

NARRATOR: It was a Friday like any other Friday. (*Julia takes a sip of coffee and continues to work.*) Julia seemed unique to her coworkers. She did not mind the drudgery of the job.

JULIA: I actually enjoy the drudgery of the job. Nice and quiet. Not like my…..old life. (*Shakes her head to rid her mind of the memories creeping in.*)

NARRATOR: Julia embraced the quietness. The simplicity. The simple joys of normalcy.

JULIA: (*Looks at watch*) Almost time for my midmorning break.

NARRATOR: And Julia's simplest and most joyful simple joy was her midmorning…

JULIA: Yogurt cup.

NARRATOR: (*same time as Julia*) With flax seeds and graham cracker crumbles.

JULIA: *(same time as Narrator)* With flax seeds and graham cracker crumbles.

RILEY: (*as grating and annoying as possible*) Hey Julia, almost time for midmorning break, huh? Yogurt again, huh?

JULIA: (*Tenses and looks annoyed*) Riley.

NARRATOR: Riley last name unknown. The bane of Julia's existence. The one annoyance capable of shattering an otherwise pleasant Friday.

JULIA: *(looks at watch)* There are still 2 minutes until break.

RILEY: C'mon now, it's Friday. Get a head start on the ol' midmorning break-er-eeno. I'll walk with ya.

JULIA: No thank you.

RILEY: What kind of yogurt did you bring today?

JULIA: (*Through gritted teeth.*) Key Lime.

RILEY: I've never tried that, is it good?

JULIA: It's fine.

NARRATOR: It was, in fact, Julia's most favoritest flavor of yogurt from her most favoritest brand. It was, however, always hard to find. And so, when it was found, and she could bring it in to work, it was a particular treat.

JULIA: Now please leave, I still have to work for *(looks at watch*) one more minute.

NARRATOR: And so Riley left. And exactly one minute later Julia locked her screen, as per company policy, stood up, straightened her outfit, and proceeded to the break room.

TAYLOR: Hey Julia, you just missed Riley.

JULIA: Taylor.

NARRATOR: Julia washed her cup. Opened the cabinet to get her bag with the flax seeds and graham cracker crumbles, and began to walk towards the refrigerator holding her yogurt.

TAYLOR: You know you are supposed to refrigerate those.

JULIA: What?

TAYLOR: Flax seeds. You are supposed to refrigerate them. After opening, I mean.

JULIA: I'll do that from now on. Thank you.

TAYLOR: No problem-o.

JULIA: *(Opens refrigerator. Pauses.*) Where is my yogurt?

NARRATOR: There was no yogurt. Of any kind. No raspberry, Or blueberry. No mixed berry. And especially not any Key Lime.

JULIA: Taylor?

TAYLOR: Couldn't tell ya. (*Pause, snaps fingers*) Oh, Riley grabbed a yogurt out of the fridge. Said something about you wanting feedback on if it was a good flavor or not?

JULIA: What?

TAYLOR: Yeah, took a couple bites then pitched it in the trash. Said it was tart.

JULIA: *(looking in the trash. Picks up yogurt, there is a coffee ground filter on top of it.*) My yogurt.

TAYLOR: Oh yeah, I just made a pot of coffee, we need more filters.

JULIA: My yogurt.

NARRATOR: Julia held in her hand her yogurt. Two spoonfuls missing, covered in old coffee grounds. Her simple joy. Robbed from her. By a sniveling, annoying, coward.

JULIA; Where's Riley? Office?

TAYLOR: Nopers. Riley said working was for suckers and decided to take off early. Car is gone. Riley is taking the early weekend. Not like us good eggs. And Riley's the leader for the promotion, if you can believe that. Makes no sense.

NARRATOR: Julia barely contained her rage.

JULIA: Is the boss in?

NARRATOR: Julia didn't wait for a reply, she simply walked steadily to the boss' office.

JULIA: Got a second?

BOSS: Julia! For you? Always. How is my favorite worker bee?

JULIA: I need Riley's home address.

BOSS: Well, Julia, you know I can't give out that information.

JULIA: I'm going to ask one more time, I need Riley's home address.

BOSS: You are scaring me, here. I've never seen you like this before, who are you?

JULIA: Who am I? (*Dramatic pause. Her face turns menacing.)* I'm me.

(*JULIA grabs the boss by the hair or tie, slams head to desk, then does it twice more.)*

JULIA: The address.

BOSS: Stop! Please! I have a family! Two beautiful golden retrievers!

JULIA: If you want to see your family again, give me the address. I don't hurt dogs though.

BOSS: You misunderstand, my family *is* the dogs.

JULIA: Oh. That complicates matters. I guess this is just between you and me. And my fists.

NARRATOR: In that moment, Julia became who she used to be. The person she thought she had buried. But she forgot one thing: You can't bury fists. (*Slight pause.*) Because you need them for other things, like eating and typing and showering and scratching that itch that you sometimes get between your shoulder blades.

BOSS: Not the fists!

(*JULIA repeatedly punches boss.*)

BOSS; Her fists are so furious!

JULIA: The address!

BOSS: 1111 Circle Cove Boulevard! Apartment C12!

JULIA: (*Lets go of boss*) I quit. (*Boss falls to ground.*)

NARRATOR: The rage had broken through like the phoenix of old. Julia was on a mission. One thought: Revenge.

(*Julia exits by standing upstage, back to performer 2.*)

TAYLOR: Hey! Are you going to eat this? Guess not. I think I can eat around the coffee grounds here. (*Tastes.*) It is a little tart….

NARRATOR: Flashback.

JULIA: (*On Phone.*) Yeah. I'm at the statue in the park. I don't see you. (*Looks at watch*) Two minutes out? You'll be late. You know how I feel about time.

NARRATOR: Five years ago. Griffith, Indiana. It was mentioned in a movie once. Other than that, relatively unknown.

JULIA: Cold.

NARRATOR: Julia has been here for three days. Observing. Gathering intelligence. Now she's waiting for her handler.

JULIA: Hey.

HANDLER: Protocol, Jules.

JULIA: Kleenex. Xerox. Spongebob. Orange. Four thousand. Red. Ernest Hemingway.

HANDLER: :Pigeon.

JULIA: So, are we a go?

HANDLER: There's a slight change.

JULIA: I don't like changes.

HANDLER: Unavoidable.

JULIA: What's the update?

HANDLER: There's a dog now.

JULIA: I don't do dogs. I'm out.

HANDLER: Wait.

JULIA: What?

HANDLER: It needs rescued.

JULIA: I'm listening.

HANDLER: Along with a cat, a ferret, and two gerbils.

JULIA: I'm not good with cats.

HANDLER: You'll make it work.

JULIA: When's the insertion?

HANDLER: That hasn't changed. Tonight.

JULIA: After this, I'm out. I'm serious.

HANDLER: Sure you are. Good luck, Jules.

JULIA: (*Checks watch*) Yeah.

NARRATOR: Later that night. In an old warehouse on Reeder Road.

BAD GUY 1: Cold out. Why are we guarding these animals anyway?

BAD GUY 2: The Boss wants them guarded. We guard them. You know pets are good for overall feeling of well being.

BAD GUY 1: No kidding?

BAD GUY 2: Did you hear that?

BAD GUY 1: No, what. Wait, Yeah. It sounds like. OW! *(Bad Guy 1 gets knocked down*.)

NARRATOR: It was the sound of an approaching fist. A furious fist.

BAD GUY 2: Where did you go?? Who's out there?

JULIA: I am.

BAD GUY 2: Do you know who owns this warehouse? The boss never forgets! Revenge will be the focus after this. Everything you love will be taken from you.

JULIA: I don't care.

(*JULIA proceeds to beat up Bad Guy 2. Bad Guy 2 can ad lib painful exclamations.)*

BAD GUY 2: Her fists are so furious!

JULIA: (*Holding Bad Guy's head up*) Where are the animals?

NARRATOR: Julia successfully rescued the dog, cat, ferret, and two gerbils. There was also a goldfish, but it was like in a 75 gallon tank and that was just unrealistic to carry out. (*Awkward Pause*). Present Day.

JULIA: *(knocking on apartment door)* Open up, Riley! Open this door now!

OLD LADY: What's all of this racket out here now?

JULIA: Sorry, ma'am. Have you seen Riley?

OLD LADY: What do you want with that evil?

JULIA: What do you mean, "evil"?

OLD LADY: Don't you know?

JULIA: Know what?

OLD LADY: Riley is the overboss of the most powerful crime syndicate in the lower Eastern Western Mid-West.

JULIA: Riley?

OLD LADY: Several years ago, one of Riley's warehouses was raided and all the pets kept there were stolen. Well, except for the goldfish. Ever since that day, all Riley can think about is revenge. Revenge on the woman who did this.

JULIA: Why are you telling me this?

OLD LADY: Because you are the woman who took those pets. You are the one. And you've been hurt, haven't you? Something has been taken from you just as you took something from Riley?

JULIA: My yogurt.

OLD LADY: What flavor?

JULIA: Key Lime.

OLD LADY: Oh dear.

JULIA: Where is Riley?

OLD LADY: Your fists are indeed, furious, young lady. But Riley is a different creature. Trained all over the world. By the very best. Do you know Mike Tyson?

JULIA: I do.

OLD LADY: Could you get me an autograph?

JULIA: I don't know him in that way.

OLD LADY: Too bad.

JULIA: Why are you telling me this?

OLD LADY: I'm the older, wiser person who advises the hero. It's my job. Also, I'm Riley's mother and Riley told me this morning I was to be put in a home.

JULIA: Where do I go next?

OLD LADY: You need trained. I know someone. They are very good at training montages. And that is what you need if you are to face Riley.

JULIA: It's too late for training montage.

OLD LADY: It's never too late. Go to this address. Ask for The Pigeon.

JULIA: Wait.

OLD LADY: Yes.

JULIA: So, I really am back.

NARRATOR: Julia went to the address the old lady gave her. As she feared, it was to her old handler, known only as The Pigeon.

JULIA: Hey.

HANDLER: Protocol, Jules.

JULIA: Enough of that. I need a training montage. I need to finish old business. And new business. All of the business.

HANDLER: Are you ready?

JULIA: I'm ready.

HANDLER: Are your fists still furious?

JULIA: (*Holds them up.*) Let's find out.

(*TRAINING MONTAGE! You can be as simple or complex as you like. I would choose the extreme of either. If you want simple, have Julia throw like three punches and then move on - silly can work. Or go complex.*)

JULIA: (*Bent over / Breathing heavily.*) Am I ready?

HANDLER: Do you feel ready?

JULIA: (*Stands straight.*) I'm ready.

NARRATOR: And so Julia headed straight to the warehouse where Riley was. For the final showdown. (*Awkward pause for all.*) Oh. How does Julia know that's where to find Riley? Ummm…FLASHABACK!

JULIA: But how will I find Riley when I'm ready?

OLD LADY: Take my phone. I've got the GPS tracker on each other's phones. It'll show you exactly where to go when you are ready.

JULIA: Thank you so much. This makes things so much easier to explain.

OLD LADY: Get going, time is running out.

JULIA: *(Looks at watch.*) You respect time.

OLD LADY: At my age, you must.

(*JULIA nods.*)

NARRATOR: Present Day. Warehouse. Oh, also it's abandoned, so no innocents. Just Riley, And some total "C" level bad guys. Easy fight before the boss level.

BAD GUY 1: Warm out. Why are we guarding the boss and the goldfish anyway?

BAD GUY 2: The Boss wants guarded. We guard. I once had a goldfish. Won it from a carnival. One of those throw the ping pong balls in the bowl games?

BAD GUY 1: No kidding?

BAD GUY 2: It died three days later.

BAD GUY 1: Tough break.

BAD GUY 2: Did you hear that?

BAD GUY 1: No, what. Wait, Yeah. It sounds like. OW! (*Bad Guy 1 gets knocked down.*)

NARRATOR: It was the sound of an approaching fist. A furious fist.

BAD GUY 2: Where did you go?? Who's out there?

JULIA: I am.

BAD GUY 2: Do you know who owns this warehouse? The boss never forgets! Revenge will be the focus after this. Everything you love will be taken from you.

JULIA: I've heard that before. But jokes on you, I have nothing left to be taken. My yogurt is gone forever.

(*JULIA proceeds to beat up Bad Guy 2*)

BAD GUY 2: Her fists are so furious!

JULIA: (*Holding Bad Guy's head up*) Where's Riley?

RILEY: Riley is right here.

JULIA: Riley.

RILEY: Julia.

JULIA: So it comes to this.

RILEY: Betrayed by my own mother.

JULIA: No. You betrayed you. You took my yogurt.

RILEY: It was the perfect plan. Wait until you retire. Get used to a quiet life. Rediscover the simple joys of life. Wait until you focus on one simple joy in particular, then rob you of it.

JULIA: You could never have known.

RILEY: Who left the coupon for yogurt on your desk one day?

JULIA: No.

RILEY: Who had Taylor forward you the article about flax seeds and graham crackers for texture?

JULIA: You monster.

RILEY: Who went into your favorite supermarket every Saturday morning before you got there and bought all of your favorite yogurt so you valued it more?

JULIA: It's rare.

RILEY: It's literally not. It's like the worst flavor of the entire line.

JULIA: Liar! The worst flavor is boysenberry.

RILEY: I forgot about boysenberry.

JULIA: Let's do this.

RILEY: Revenge!

(*They fight. As complex and simple as desired. It should end, as has been the trend, with Julia holding Riley and pummeling with fists.)*

RILEY: Her fists are so furious!

(Julia has her fist cocked, about to deliver the final blow.)

RILEY: Go on! End it!

JULIA: Key Lime!

HANDLER: Stop! You left this life.

OLD LADY: I'm Riley's mother.

TAYLOR: Flax seeds need refrigerated.

BAD GUY 2: I won a goldfish.

HANDLER: You aren't that person any longer.

JULIA: I am who I am.

OLD LADY: I don't want to go in a home.

BAD GUY 2: I miss my goldfish sometimes.

TAYLOR: There's nothing wrong with boysenberry.

HANDLER: You are not defined by your past.

RILEY: Just do it already!

JULIA: (*Pause)* No. *(Let's Riley go.*) I'm done.

NARRATOR: And so Julia walked into the night. In search of a frozen yogurt shop where you can mix in an assortment of toppings. It was that sort of night. As for Riley…

RILEY: *(Picks Self Up)* Big Mistake. I don't forget. Get ready for Part 2. Wait, what was that? Did anyone hear that? OW. (*Riley gets knocked out.*)

JULIA: Treat your mother right, Riley. (*To Bad Guy 2*) Can you give the goldfish a good home?

BAD GUY 2: Really? Yes. I will love it with all my heart.

JULIA: It's yours. Remember, you can leave behind who you were. Take the goldfish. Forge a new life.

BAD GUY 2: I will. I won't let you down.

JULIA: Maybe something good did come from all of this. Now to get that frozen yogurt. And a new job.

END PLAY